Historically, the Balkans means the area of south-east Europe that used to be under Ottoman rule. (It was once also a way of naming Europe, as seen from Ottoman Istanbul and, before that, from Byzantine Constantinople.) The loss of the Balkans was a terrible blow to the Turks and, in some quarters of Turkey, it is a matter for grief and regret even today. Modern Turkey sees itself as a player in the region. It is an important investor and a political force sympathetic to the region's development, and caring for the situation of its Muslim population. But with President Erdoğan's policies at home and abroad, many in the West have some worries about Turkish influence in the Western Balkans too.

The Turkish perspective on the history of the region (and, by extrapolation, to some extent also on its present and future) is, naturally, quite different from that of the Greeks and the Slavic nations of south-east Europe. For the Turks, these nations stabbed the Ottoman Empire in the back, after it had provided for centuries a stability and a peace that the region had not previously enjoyed – a view that is not entirely without substance.

Some Turks concluded that the key mistake that led to the loss of the Balkans was made with the decision not to force the Muslim religion upon the subject people,[24] which would also confirm the view that the Orthodox Church needs to be credited for the survival of the Balkan nations. In Bosnia, on the other hand, the lack of a comparably strong Church organisation and the presence of a distinctive Christian sect called Bogomilism, with some theological features close to Islam, made conversion easier. Essentially, though, accepting Islam under Ottoman rule meant, above all, an opportunity to climb up the social ladder of Bosnia at the time. Still, only a relatively small part of the Balkans actually converted to Islam and these peoples were seen by their Orthodox neighbours simply as 'Turks' until very recently. (This is where the historical roots for the dislike between the Serbs and the Albanians in Kosovo or the Serbs and the Muslims in Bosnia lie.) Today, Islamic Eastern Europe includes Albania, Kosovo, parts of North Macedonia and Bosnia – places that are usually associated with ethnic conflicts and/or war. But very few people in the West realise that these are actually the only European countries with an indigenous Muslim population. It is *the* centre of European Islam, much more so than the UK, France or Germany where Muslim populations are the